Delhi took time to grasp the enormous economic, strategic and diplomatic benefit of having a large and generally prosperous diaspora. Now, however, the Indian government views the diaspora as an extension of India's influence abroad and an additional source of prestige. A separate Union ministry dealing with non-resident Indian affairs was set up early in the first decade of the next century. The first conference for overseas Indians (Pravasi Bharatiya) sponsored by the Government of India was held in 2003 during which ten eminent persons of Indian origin were officially honoured. The idea of giving some form of dual citizenship – overseas Indian citizenship – is also of recent origin.[41]

These days, foreign citizens of Indian origin play an active role in determining policy towards India in countries such as the United States, the United Kingdom, Australia and Canada. Indians were always described as global ambassadors and were asked to uphold India's name and honour internationally. Nehru once remarked, 'If you cannot be, and if you are not, friendly to the people of that country, come back to India and do not spoil the fair name of India.'[42] It is unlikely that he envisaged a time when Canada's federal cabinet would have six members of Indian origin, including the defence minister, as happened after the 2015 election that resulted in Justin Trudeau becoming prime minister. At the same time, both Canada and the United States had persons of Indian origin as ambassadors to India.

In 1947, there were 3,410,215 persons of Indian origin in the British dominion and colonies: 700,000 in Burma, 700,000 in Ceylon, 700,000 in Malaya, 282,400 in South Africa, 184,100 in British East Africa, 271,640 in Mauritius (64 per cent of population), 125,675 in Fiji (47 per cent of population), 406,000 in British West Indies, 30,000 in Indonesia, 4,000 in the Persian Gulf (Oman, Kuwait, Bahrain), 2,500 in Iran, 1,000 in Egypt, 700 in Iraq and 200 in Afghanistan.[43] As of 2015, there are over twenty-seven million people of Indian origin, including temporary migrants, with